



ABES
Engineering College
College Code 032

SOFT SKILLS

Unit 1: Subject- Verb Agreement

SEEP DEPARTMENT

Word Formation

- **Root Word:**

Definition: The base part of a word carrying core meaning.

Examples: act (action), write (rewrite)

Link: <https://www.thoughtco.com/root-words-1691904>

- **Bound Words:**

Definition: Morphemes that cannot stand alone as words.

Examples: -ness (happiness), un- (unhappy)

Link: <https://www.thoughtco.com/bound-morpheme-words-1691727>

- **Affixes:**

Definition: Prefixes/suffixes added to a root to change meaning.

Examples: dis- (dislike), -ful (joyful)

Link: <https://www.thoughtco.com/affix-words-1691861>

- **Compound Words:**

Definition: Words formed by joining two or more words.

Examples: toothbrush, raincoat

Link: <https://www.thoughtco.com/compound-words-1690491>

- **Acronyms:**

Definition: Words formed from initials of other words.

Examples: NASA, UNESCO

Link: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Acronym>

- **Abbreviations:**

Definition: Shortened forms of words/phrases.

Examples: Dr. (Doctor), ASAP (as soon as possible)

Link: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Abbreviation>

- **Conversion:**

Definition: Changing a word's function without altering its form.

Examples: Google (verb), butter (verb)

Link: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Conversion_\(linguistics\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Conversion_(linguistics))

- **Back Formation:**

Definition: Forming a new word by removing affixes.

Examples: edit from editor, burgle from burglar

Link: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Back-formation>

- **Blending:**

Definition: Merging parts of two words into one.

Examples: brunch (breakfast+lunch), smog (smoke+fog)

Link: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Blend_word

- **Clipping:**

Definition: Shortening a longer word.

Examples: exam (examination), phone (telephone)

Link: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Clipping_\(morphology\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Clipping_(morphology))

- **Derivation:**

Definition: Forming a new word by adding derivational affixes.

Examples: happiness, unfriendly

Link: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Derivation_\(linguistics\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Derivation_(linguistics))

Vocabulary Building

- **Antonyms:**

Definition: Words with opposite meanings.

Examples: hot <-> cold, success <-> failure

Link: <https://www.thoughtco.com/antonym-words-1691879>

- **Synonyms:**

Definition: Words with similar meanings.

Examples: big <-> large, smart <-> intelligent

Link: <https://www.thesaurus.com/>

- **Homophones:**

Cheat Sheet: Word Formation, Vocabulary & Subject-Verb Agreement

Definition: Words that sound the same but differ in meaning/spelling.

Examples: pair/pear, right/write

Link: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/homophones/>

Subject-Verb Agreement & Verb Types

- **Finite Verb:**

Definition: Verb form that changes with tense/person/number.

Examples: She runs, They played

Link: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/finite-and-nonfinite-verbs/>

- **Non-finite Verb:**

Definition: Verb form not limited by tense/person/number.

Examples: to read, reading books

Link: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/finite-and-nonfinite-verbs/>

- **Gerund:**

Definition: Verb ending in -ing used as a noun.

Examples: Swimming is fun, I love reading

Link: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/gerund/>

- **Infinitive:**

Definition: Base form of verb often with 'to'.

Examples: to dance, to learn

Link: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/infinitive/>

- **Participle Verb:**

Definition: Verb form used as adjective or in verb tense formation.

Examples: The running water, Baked bread

Link: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/partici>

RULES

Subject – Verb Agreement

Agreement of a verb with its subject.

Thumb Rule

- A singular subject demands a singular verb; a plural subject demands a plural verb. That is the simple principle behind subject-verb agreement.
 - The *list* of items *is* on the desk.
 - The *dog growls* when he is angry.
 - The *dogs growl* when they are angry.

Use of Indefinite Pronouns

- Indefinite pronouns such as everyone and everybody feel plural to some writers, but they are always singular — and take a singular verb.
 - *Everyone* associated with the project *is* proud to be part of the effort.
 - Someone has to be responsible
- Don't be confused by phrases that come between the subject pronoun and its verb — phrases that may contain plural words.
 - *Each* of the project partners *is* responsible for writing a chapter summary.

Use of few, many, several, etc.

- Determiners like few, many, several, both, some, etc. always take plural form.
 - *Few were left alive after the flood.*
 - *Many were against the system.*

Off to use “of”

- A subject will come before a phrase beginning with “of”. This is a key rule for understanding subjects. The word “of” is the culprit in many, perhaps most, subject-verb mistakes.
 - **Incorrect:** *A bouquet of yellow roses lend color and fragrance to the room.*
 - **Correct:** *A bouquet of yellow roses lends . . . (bouquet lends, not roses lend)*

Use of *or, either/ or, or neither/ nor*

- ***Two singular subjects connected by or, either/ or, or neither/ nor require a singular verb.***
- ***Examples:***
 - *My aunt or my uncle is arriving by train today.*
 - *Neither Juan nor Carmen is available.*
 - *Either Kiana or Casey is helping today with stage decorations.*

Use of *or, either/ or, or neither/ nor...Contd.*

- ***The verb in an or, either /or, or neither /nor sentence agrees with the noun or pronoun closest to it.***
- **Examples:**
 - *Neither the plates nor the serving bowl goes on that shelf.*
 - *Neither the serving bowl nor the plates go on that shelf.*

Use of conjunction “and”

- *As a general rule, use a plural verb with two or more subjects when they are connected by “and”.*

Example: *A car and a bike are my means of transportation.*

Exceptions: *-Breaking and entering is against the law.*

-The bed and breakfast was charming.

In those sentences, “breaking and entering” and “bed and breakfast” are compound nouns.

“Along With”, “As Well As”, “Besides”

- *Sometimes the subject is separated from the verb by such words as “along with”, “as well as”, “besides”, not, etc. These words and phrases are not part of the subject. Ignore them and use a singular verb when the subject is singular.*
- **Examples:**
 - *The politician, along with the newsmen, is expected shortly.*
 - *Excitement, as well as nervousness, is the cause of her shaking.*

Nouns in plural form

- ***Some nouns which are plural in form but singular in meaning, take a singular verb.***
 - The news is false.
 - Mathematics is my favourite subject.

Agreement with distances, periods of time, sums of money...

- ***Use a singular verb with distances, periods of time, sums of money, etc., when considered as a unit.***
- ***Examples:***
 - *Three miles is too far to walk.*
 - *Five years is the maximum sentence for that offense.*
 - *Ten dollars is a high price to pay.*

Agreement with Collective Nouns

- *Some collective nouns, such as family, couple, staff, audience, etc., may take either a singular or a plural verb, depending on their use in the sentence.*
- **Examples:**
 - *Mr. Rajesh is our administrative staff.*
 - *The staff of hospital need to learn the skills of communication.*

Agreement with words that indicate portions

- *With words that indicate portions—a lot, a majority, some, all, etc. we are guided by the noun after of. If the noun after of is singular, use a singular verb. If it is plural, use a plural verb.*
- **Examples:**
 - A lot of the **pie** has disappeared.*
 - A lot of the **pies** have disappeared.*
 - A third of the **city** is unemployed.*
 - A third of the **people** are unemployed.*
 - All of the **pie** is gone.*
 - All of the **pies** are gone.*

References

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